

ParaLife Trees

Planting a Life in Paradise

Slicing Tomato Seedling Grow Guide

Transplanting | Spacing | Feeding | Pest Control | Disease Control | Harvesting

Quick Fact	Recommended Range
Tomato type	Large slicing/sandwich tomato seedlings
Seedling transplant age	5-8 weeks from sowing, or 6-10 inches tall
Best transplant size	4-6 true leaves, thick stem, healthy green leaves
Main customer use	Small farmers planting trays; home gardeners planting 2-6 plants
First harvest estimate	65-90 days after transplanting for most slicing types

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This guide is designed for customers buying slicing tomato seedlings from ParaLife Trees - including small farmers planting trays and home gardeners planting a few plants.

1. Quick Rescue Chart: If You See This, Do This

Use this page first. Check the underside of leaves and the soft new growth before spraying or fertilizing.

What you see	Most likely cause	First action today
Tiny white insects fly up when plant is touched	Whiteflies	Spray leaf undersides. Add yellow sticky traps. Repeat every 3-5 days.
Leaves curling; sticky leaves; ants on plant	Aphids or whiteflies	Check under leaves. Spray mild soap solution. Control ants. Repeat every 3-5 days.
Bronze/silver marks; damaged flowers or new leaves	Thrips	Remove badly damaged growth. Use sticky traps. Treat early.
Holes in leaves or fruit; black droppings	Hornworm/fruitworm/caterpillar	Check early morning/evening. Handpick. Remove damaged fruit.
Lower leaves with brown target-like spots	Early blight	Remove affected lower leaves. Mulch. Avoid splashing soil onto leaves.
Many tiny brown spots; yellowing leaves	Septoria leaf spot	Remove spotted leaves. Improve airflow. Keep leaves dry.
Plant wilts suddenly but soil is moist	Bacterial wilt/root disease	Remove badly collapsed plants. Do not reuse infected soil. Rotate crops.
Blossom end turns black/brown and sunken	Blossom-end rot	Water consistently. Mulch. Avoid heavy nitrogen. Add calcium only if soil needs it.
Fruit cracks near stem	Uneven watering/rain after dry spell	Keep moisture even. Harvest breaker-stage fruit before heavy rain.
Mottled leaves; twisted growth; stunting	Virus, including mosaic viruses	Remove badly infected plants. Control insects. Wash hands/tools. Avoid tobacco handling.

Important: If the plant is newly transplanted, do not rush with strong fertilizer. Let it settle for 7-14 days unless it is clearly nutrient-starved.

2. Common Tomato Pests: Fast Identification

Pest	Signs	Action range
Whiteflies	Tiny white flies under leaves; yellowing; sticky honeydew; can spread viruses	Spray undersides every 3-5 days. Add yellow sticky traps. Remove weeds.
Aphids	Soft insects on new growth; curling; sticky leaves; ants	Spray with water first. Use mild soap spray. Repeat every 3-5 days.
Thrips	Silver/bronze streaks; distorted flowers/new growth; fruit scarring	Use sticky traps. Remove damaged flowers. Treat early.
Spider mites	Fine speckles; webbing; dusty dry leaves	Spray undersides. Avoid drought stress. Repeat every 3-5 days.
Tomato hornworm / fruitworm	Large holes, chewed fruit, black droppings	Handpick early morning/evening. Remove damaged fruit.
Leaf miner	White winding trails inside leaves	Remove mined leaves early. Use sanitation and sticky traps.
Nematodes	Poor growth; yellowing; swollen root knots	Rotate crops. Use clean soil/media. Add organic matter. Avoid reusing infected soil.

Soap spray customer guide: Mix 1 teaspoon mild liquid soap in 1 litre of water. Spray a few leaves first as a test. Spray early morning or late evening, not in hot sun. Rinse plant the next morning if leaves look stressed.

Farmer note: Scout at least twice weekly. In hot, dry periods, check every 1-2 days because mites and thrips can build up quickly.

3. Common Diseases + Tobacco Handling Warning

Problem	Signs	First action
Early blight	Brown target-like spots, usually lower leaves first	Remove affected leaves. Mulch. Stake plants. Avoid overhead watering.
Septoria leaf spot	Many small spots; yellowing leaves; leaf drop	Remove infected leaves. Improve airflow. Do not wet foliage.
Bacterial spot/speck	Dark leaf spots; rough spots on fruit	Avoid touching wet plants. Remove infected debris. Use clean tools.
Fusarium/Verticillium wilt	Yellowing/wilting, often one side first	Remove infected plants. Rotate tomato/pepper/eggplant family crops.
Bacterial wilt	Sudden wilt while soil is moist	Remove plant and surrounding soil if severe. Do not compost infected plant.
Mosaic viruses/TMV	Mottled leaves, distortion, stunting, reduced fruit	Wash hands/tools. Avoid tobacco products around seedlings. Remove badly infected plants.
Blossom-end rot	Black/brown sunken end on fruit	Keep soil moisture even. Mulch. Avoid excess nitrogen.

Tobacco warning: Cigarettes and other tobacco products can carry tobacco mosaic virus. Smokers or anyone handling tobacco should wash hands well with soap before touching tomato seedlings, trays, tools, leaves, stakes, or fruit. Do not smoke while handling tomato seedlings.

Do not touch tomato plants when leaves are wet unless necessary. Wet leaves spread bacterial and fungal problems more easily.

4. Slicing Tomato Quick Facts and Growth Numbers

Item	Specific range
Seed germination	5-10 days in warm, moist seedling mix; slower if cool
Seed to transplant age	5-8 weeks from sowing
Best transplant height	6-10 inches tall; sturdy stem; 4-6 true leaves
Hardening-off period	7-10 days before full field sun
Root settling after transplant	7-14 days
First flowering after transplant	20-35 days, depending on seedling age and variety
Flower to full-size fruit	About 25-35 days
First harvest after transplant	65-90 days for most large slicing tomatoes
Full sun target	6-8 hours minimum; 8-10 hours best
Good daytime temperature	21-29 C / 70-85 F
Pollination stress range	Above 32 C / 90 F daytime or above 24 C / 75 F nighttime
Expected yield, good home-garden plant	10-20 lb / 4.5-9 kg per plant with good care

These are customer-ready ranges. Actual timing varies with variety, root strength, rainfall, temperature, sunlight, spacing, pruning, and feeding.

5. From Tray to Field or Home Garden: Transplanting

This is the most important section for customers buying seedlings in trays.

Before removing seedlings from the tray:

- Water the tray 1-2 hours before transplanting.
- Transplant in the evening after 4:30 p.m. or on a cloudy day.
- Do not pull seedlings by the stem. Push or loosen from below and hold the root ball.
- Keep the root ball together as much as possible.
- Plant immediately; do not leave roots exposed to sun or wind.

Planting depth:

- Normal seedlings: plant slightly deeper than the tray plug, covering the plug by about 1 inch.
- Tall/leggy seedlings: remove the lowest leaves and bury part of the stem 2-3 inches deep to encourage extra roots.
- Do not bury leaves under soil.

After transplanting:

- Water immediately.
- Shade lightly for 1-2 days if the sun is very harsh.
- Check every day for the first 7 days.
- Avoid strong fertilizer for the first 7-14 days unless plants are clearly hungry.

6. Hardening Off Before Full Sun

Hardening off helps tray seedlings adjust from nursery conditions to direct sun, wind, and field heat.

Day	Sun exposure target	What to watch
1-2	1-2 hours morning sun only	Leaves should not wilt badly or burn
3-4	3-4 hours morning sun	Keep tray moist, not soaked
5-6	4-6 hours sun; include light midday sun if plant looks strong	Watch for curling/wilting
7-10	Full sun for most of the day	Ready to transplant if leaves stay firm

Shortcut warning: Seedlings moved from shade to full sun in one day can wilt, scorch, stall for 7-14 days, or die. Harden them off gradually.

If customers bought seedlings already exposed to sun, still let them rest in a bright protected area for 12-24 hours before transplanting.

7. Spacing Guide for Small Farmers and Home Gardens

Planting style	Plant spacing	Row spacing / container
Small farmer, staked rows	18-24 inches between plants	4-5 feet between rows for walking, spraying, harvesting
Small farmer, wider disease-control spacing	24-36 inches between plants	4-5 feet between rows
Home garden bed	24-36 inches between plants	Keep at least 2 feet around each plant if possible
Container growing	1 plant per pot	Minimum 5 gallons; 10-15 gallons better for slicing tomatoes
If variety is unknown	Use 24-36 inches	Wider spacing lowers disease pressure

Simple field line: Plant - 2 ft - Plant - 2 ft - Plant. Leave 4-5 ft between rows so you can water, spray, weed, prune, stake, and harvest without breaking plants.

Do not crowd slicing tomatoes. Crowding increases leaf wetness, early blight, Septoria leaf spot, whiteflies, poor airflow, and small fruit.

8. Soil, Water, Sunlight, and Climate

Need	Specific target
Sunlight	6-8 hours minimum; 8-10 hours best for fruiting
Soil	Loose, well-drained, rich in compost/organic matter
Soil pH target	6.0-6.8 preferred
Water after transplanting	Water immediately; keep evenly moist for first 14 days
General water target	1-2 inches water per week in soil; pots may need daily checks
Best watering time	Morning before 9:00 a.m.; avoid wet leaves at night
Mulch depth	2-3 inches dry grass/leaves/compost; keep 2 inches from stem
Heat stress	Above 32 C / 90 F can reduce fruit set, especially with dry soil

Water the soil, not the leaves. Wet leaves plus poor airflow can increase fungal and bacterial diseases.

For home gardeners, a simple test is to push one finger 1 inch into the soil. If that top inch is dry, water deeply.

9. Feeding Schedule for Slicing Tomatoes

Stage	Timing	Feeding direction
At planting	Day 0	Compost or well-rotted manure mixed into hole/bed. Optional starter feed.
Settling stage	Days 1-14	Do not overfeed. Keep moisture even so roots establish.
Early growth	Days 14-28	Light balanced feeding to build roots and leaves.
First flowers	About 20-35 days after transplant	Reduce heavy nitrogen. Support flowering with potassium, phosphorus, calcium.
Fruit sizing	About 25-35 days after flowers	Keep watering consistent. Feed lightly every 2-4 weeks if needed.
Harvest period	65-90 days onward	Maintain steady moisture and light feeding. Do not push too much nitrogen.

Avoid too much nitrogen: It can make a big green plant with fewer flowers and softer growth that pests enjoy.

Do not put fresh manure directly against tomato roots. It can burn roots and increase disease risk.

10. Staking, Pruning, and Mulching

Large slicing tomatoes should be supported. Support improves airflow, keeps fruit off the soil, makes spraying easier, and reduces damaged fruit.

Task	When	Specific instruction
Stake/cage	At transplanting or within 7 days	Install support early to avoid root damage later.
Tie plant	Every 7-10 days as it grows	Use soft tie. Do not cut into stem.
Remove low leaves	When plant is 12-18 inches tall	Remove leaves touching soil or within 6-8 inches of soil.
Prune suckers	For staked/vining plants	Remove some lower suckers; do not over-prune in hot sun.
Mulch	After watering in	Use 2-3 inches mulch, kept 2 inches away from stem.

For small farmers, tying and pruning every week is easier than waiting until plants fall over. Heavy plants with fruit can break quickly after rain or wind.

11. Healthy Leaf Color and Problem Signs

Leaf/plant appearance	Possible meaning	First action
Medium to deep green	Normal healthy growth	Continue steady watering and weekly checks
Light green new leaves only	Often normal if it darkens in 7-14 days	Watch; do not rush fertilizer
Pale whole plant	Low nitrogen, poor soil, low sunlight, water stress	Check sun/water first, then feed lightly
Yellow lower leaves	Age, overwatering, nitrogen shortage, disease start	Remove if spotted; check drainage
Brown target spots on lower leaves	Early blight	Remove lower infected leaves; mulch
Many small spots	Septoria leaf spot	Remove spotted leaves; improve airflow
Purple stems/leaves	Cool stress or phosphorus stress	Warm soil, improve roots, balanced feeding
Curling with sticky leaves	Aphids/whiteflies or virus	Check undersides; treat pests; isolate bad plants
Mosaic/mottled pattern	Possible virus	Wash hands/tools; remove severely infected plants

12. Flowering and Fruiting Problems

Problem	Likely cause	What to do
Flowers dropping	Heat above 32 C / 90 F, water stress, too much nitrogen	Water evenly. Mulch. Reduce nitrogen. Improve airflow.
Leaves but few flowers	Too much nitrogen or too little sun	Give 6-8+ hours sun. Switch to fruiting support.
Blossom-end rot	Uneven water; calcium movement problem	Water consistently. Mulch. Avoid overfertilizing. Test soil if repeated.
Fruit cracking	Dry spell followed by heavy rain/watering	Keep moisture even. Harvest pink/breaker fruit before heavy rain.
Small fruit	Crowding, heat, low feeding, poor roots	Wider spacing, steady water, light feeding, mulch.
Sunscald	Fruit exposed to harsh sun after over-pruning	Do not strip too many leaves. Keep some canopy over fruit.
Catfacing/deformed fruit	Flower stress, thrips, temperature stress	Remove badly deformed fruit. Manage thrips and stress.

Tomato flowers are self-pollinating, but wind or gentle vibration helps pollen move. In calm home gardens, gently tap flower clusters around late morning when flowers are dry.

13. Harvesting Slicing Tomatoes

Harvest point	What it means
Breaker stage	First pink/red/yellow color shows at blossom end; good before heavy rain or transport
Firm ripe stage	Full color, still firm; best for salad/sandwich slicing
Soft ripe stage	Full color and soft; best used immediately
Harvest frequency	Every 2-4 days when plants are producing heavily
Field handling	Keep out of hot sun after picking. Do not pile too deep.
Home handling	Store ripe tomatoes at room temperature for best flavor; use quickly.

For small farmers: pick firm, clean fruit in the morning. Grade out cracked, insect-damaged, or diseased fruit so they do not spoil good fruit in the container.

For home gardeners: harvesting slightly early at breaker stage can reduce cracking, bird damage, and fruitworm damage.

14. Weekly Care Checklist + ParaLife Trees Support

Every 1-2 days:

- Check soil moisture.
- Look under leaves for whiteflies, aphids, mites, and thrips.
- Check for wilting, curling, new spots, and broken stems.
- Check flowers and young fruit for pest damage.

Every 7 days:

- Tie plants to stakes.
- Remove leaves touching soil.
- Remove spotted or diseased leaves.
- Weed around plants.
- Check mulch and airflow.
- Scout the whole row or garden bed.

Need help with your tomato seedlings?

Send clear photos of the full plant, top leaves, underside of leaves, stem base, soil/pot, and any insects or fruit damage.

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Sources used: Trinidad & Tobago Ministry of Agriculture tomato factsheet; University of Minnesota Extension tomato guide; University of Maryland Extension tomato guide; Cornell tomato disease guidance; Michigan State University and Kansas State Extension tobacco mosaic guidance; South Dakota State Extension tomato harvest/yield notes.